

The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra of the Perfection of Wisdom, the Vajra Victory Banner

Ārya-prajñāpāramitā-vajra-ketu-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 30 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཤེས་རབ་ཀྱི་རལ་ཏུ་ཕྱུ་བ་རྩོད་ལྷ་མཚན་

Toh 30 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in English as the Noble Perfection of Wisdom, the Vajra Victory Banner, in Sanskrit as the Ārya-prajñāpāramitā-vajra-ketu-mahāyāna-sūtra, and in Tibetan as འཕགས་པ་ཤེས་རབ་ཀྱི་རལ་ཏུ་ཕྱུ་བ་རྩོད་ལྷ་མཚན་. It belongs to the Perfection of Wisdom class of texts, a large body of Mahāyāna scriptures concerned with the nature and practice of prajñāpāramitā, the transcendent wisdom that perceives the emptiness of all phenomena. This particular sūtra takes the form of a dialogue in which the bodhisattva Vajra Victory Banner, seated among an assembled retinue at Rājagṛha, questions the Buddha about the qualities that constitute the Perfection of Wisdom. It is one of the shorter works within the Perfection of Wisdom section of the Kangyur, presenting the teaching in a concise and direct exchange between the Buddha and the inquiring bodhisattva.

...the Blessed One is praised. The noble Mahāyāna sūtra of the Perfection of Wisdom of Vajrapāṇi is complete.

In the language of India: Ārya-prajñāpāramitā-vajra-ketu-mahāyāna-sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The noble Mahāyāna sūtra of the Perfection of Wisdom, the Vajra Victory Banner.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha together with a fully endowed retinue. Then, on that occasion, the bodhisattva Vajra Victory Banner, who was present in that assembly, rose from his seat and addressed the Blessed One as follows: "Blessed One, what are the qualities that constitute the Perfection of Wisdom?"

The Blessed One declared: "Vajra Victory Banner, it consists of four qualities. What are those four? They are these: recognizing all phenomena as emptiness; knowing all conditioned phenomena to be impermanent and to be suffering; being endowed with the nature of reality that is free from all conceptual elaboration; and cultivating without conceptuality and without fixation in all circumstances.

"Furthermore, there are four qualities that are the causes for wisdom to arise. What are those four? They are these: first, relying upon a teacher who is skilled in expounding the Dharma; second, hearing the sacred Dharma from that teacher; third, engaging with and reflecting upon its meaning; and fourth, being devoted to teaching others correctly. These are the causes for wisdom to arise.

"Sons of good family, furthermore, bodhisattvas should understand all phenomena to be empty by virtue of being naturally and thoroughly pure, to be without self, to be of an essential nature devoid of substantial things, to be without marks, to be neither bound nor liberated, and to be without appearance and without darkness in their intrinsic nature.

"Therefore, bodhisattvas should train in the Perfection of Wisdom. They should train in the Perfection of Wisdom by knowing that all phenomena are without arising and without abiding."

The Blessed One then declared in verse:

Cultivate the essential nature of non-substantiality.

Be devoted to the causes by which wisdom arises.

Train in the meaning of wisdom

that is free from all marks.

Having spoken these words, the Blessed One said no more. The bodhisattva Vajra Victory Banner and all the others, together with the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas of the world, rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had taught.

The noble Mahāyāna sūtra of the Perfection of Wisdom, the Vajra Victory Banner, is complete.

Translator's Notes

- The opening phrase "...the Blessed One is praised" is a sentence fragment that continues from an earlier folio not supplied here. The text begins mid-sentence; this is reproduced as given.

The term translated as "fully endowed retinue" renders "thams cad dang ldan pa'i 'khor," which literally means an assembly endowed with all the standard qualities; this is the stock phrase for the ideal monastic-and-bodhisattva gathering that typically includes monks, bodhisattvas, and other beings.

The final verse is rendered as four lines corresponding to the four metrical units of the Tibetan. The third line of the verse closely parallels the prose instruction preceding it, reinforcing that the Perfection of Wisdom to be trained in is specifically characterized by freedom from all

marks or signs.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.